GUEST GUIDE · SATURDAY 24 OCTOBER 2026

*Linh & Huy*

# The engagement · *Lễ Ăn Hỏi*

**Saturday 24 October 2026**
14:30

**The bride's family home**
550 Trần Hưng Đạo Street, Phủ Lý Ward, Ninh Bình

The Lễ Ăn Hỏi is the formal marriage proposal. The groom's family arrives in procession at the bride's family home, carrying trays of gifts, to ask for her hand. It is a short, family-centred and highly codified ceremony that seals the bond between the two families before the next day's wedding.

**ARRIVAL**
2:30 pm (the ceremony starts at 3 pm, at a time chosen as auspicious: please be on time)

**LENGTH**
About 1 h 30 of ceremony, then the reception from 4:30 pm

**DRESS**
Smart and colourful. Avoid all-white and all-black (colours of mourning)

**GIFT**
Nothing to bring or give on the day

> ***The gift trays (tráp)*** — Lacquered boxes covered in red silk, always in an odd number (5, 7 or 9). They hold betel leaves and areca nuts (trầu cau, a symbol of faithful love in Vietnamese legend), tea, liquor, fruit, rice cakes (bánh cốm, bánh phu thê, the "husband-and-wife cake") and red sticky rice (xôi gấc). Red brings luck.

## At the table

- Dishes are shared in the middle of the table: use the serving chopsticks if there are some.
- Wait for the elders to start, or to be invited to eat ("Mời!").
- Never stand your chopsticks upright in your rice: that gesture belongs to funeral rites.
- Toasts are frequent, often with beer: toasting with a soft drink is perfectly fine.

## Good to know

- Give and receive things (cup, glass, dish) with both hands.
- Greet the elders first.
- You may be asked to take your shoes off inside the house: wear shoes that slip off easily.
- Photos are welcome, but never in front of the altar during the rites.

## Weather & practical

- Late October in Ninh Bình: around 22–29 °C, humid, showers possible. Bring a light jacket and an umbrella.
- Keep some cash in Vietnamese dong (VND) on you.

## A few words

Rough pronunciation in brackets — any effort will be warmly appreciated!

**Xin chào** *(sin chow)*
Hello

**Cảm ơn** *(gahm uhn)*
Thank you

**Chúc mừng!** *(chook mung)*
Congratulations!

**Trăm năm hạnh phúc** *(chum num hahn fook)*
"A hundred years of happiness" — the classic wish to newlyweds

**Một, hai, ba, dzô!** *(mote, hi, ba, yo)*
"One, two, three, cheers!" — the toast

**Ngon quá!** *(ngon kwah)*
Delicious!

**Cô dâu · Chú rể** *(koh yoh · choo zeh)*
The bride · the groom

**Nhà trai · Nhà gái** *(nyah chai · nyah guy)*
Groom's family · bride's family

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# What happens

**14:30** ● **Guests arrive**

You are welcomed at Linh's parents' home with tea, fruit and seeds while everyone gathers.

**YOUR PART** Greet the elders first with a small nod and sit where you are shown: seats near the altar are kept for the elders of both families.

**15:00** ● **The groom's procession**

Huy's family arrives together in a line: an elder who speaks for the family leads, followed by the parents, the groom and the young people carrying the gift trays.

**YOUR PART** Stand to the side to let the procession through. A lovely moment to photograph — just don't block the way.

● **Handing over the trays**

At the entrance, each tray bearer hands their tray, face to face, to a young woman from the bride's family. The bearers receive a small red envelope (lì xì) as thanks.

**YOUR PART** If you are one of the bearers, everything will be explained on the day: simply follow the person in front of you.

● **Introductions and the proposal**

The groom's family spokesperson introduces the family and formally asks for Linh's hand; the bride's family spokesperson replies. The speeches are in Vietnamese and last about ten minutes.

**YOUR PART** This is the most solemn moment: please stay quiet and silence your phone.

● **Opening the trays, offering to the ancestors**

The trays are opened and some of the offerings are placed on the ancestral altar. The bride's parents light incense to announce the engagement to their ancestors.

**YOUR PART** Don't walk in front of the altar or touch the offerings.

● **The bride appears**

Linh, in an áo dài, comes in accompanied by her mother or a relative. Huy gives her a bouquet, then the couple serves tea to both families and together they light incense and bow at the altar.

**YOUR PART** Photo time! Follow the photographer's lead.

● **Returning the trays (lại quả)**

The bride's family gives back part of each tray's contents to the groom's family: luck is shared, never kept entirely. The families pose together for photos.

**YOUR PART** A good moment to congratulate the couple: "Chúc mừng!"

**16:30** ● **Reception**

A celebration meal is served. Dishes are placed in the middle of the table and shared.

**YOUR PART** See "At the table" overleaf. Do try a little of everything.

*Trăm năm hạnh phúc*